

across your various devices. And also try and keep an eye out for the various apps and software that the device supports – the more the capability of the device, the more number of ways you can access the data.

While you can use Youtube, or the popular social networking sites such as Facebook, or Flickr to share your photos, videos and music online, cloud storage devices seem the most viable option to store and share your data on the internet as per your requirement, and it's a no brainer as to why most of the consumers would want to shift to the cloud. It would enable us to store files online, thus releasing a lot of space on our PCs, smartphones, tablets etc. We would be able to access the files from any device, and any location as long as we have an internet connection. An added reason to go with services such as Dropbox, Sugarsync, Google Drive is that the consumer gives up the responsibility of regularly maintaining the hardware or of backing up the data. But then there are a lot of disadvantages that come with online storage, as we have seen in previous articles, and that is where the Personal cloud comes in. The Personal cloud scores in a lot of areas where online cloud storage seems shaky as an option:

- ▶ Firstly, it is much cheaper compared to online storage services. With these services, the more data you need to store – the more you'll need to pay up, with unlimited storage reaching up to around 800\$ a year. Whereas with your own personal cloud, it's just the first time investment that you'll need to bother about, and further usage is completely free. Expansion of data also would probably require you to just buy another hard disk, which turns out to be much cheaper comparatively.
- ▶ Then there's the whole dependency factor – the fact that it becomes extremely cumbersome to try and switch between providers once you've already stored huge amounts of data with a particular provider, making it very important to choose the right vendor in the first go. But, with your own personal cloud, since the data is in your control, switching between software or devices shouldn't be that much of an issue.
- ▶ With 3rd party clouds, what the provider offers is what you get. These might be limitations in terms of number of users or other limitations set by the provider regarding the data, or even the speed it takes for you to sync your data with their servers. A personal cloud gives you true flexibility in the sense that your cloud can do whatever you want, at a much faster speed, and cater to as many users as you want depending on your needs.
- ▶ Oh, and there's also the slight risk that storing data in a remote, third party server means there might be technical difficulties and server downtimes